

The Evolution of Jalen Duren's Offensive Profile

A Breakdown of Offensive Growth

Jackson Ewers
April 2026



Introduction

Just three seasons after from a 14-68 campaign, the Detroit Pistons have undergone one of the league's most dramatic turnarounds, evolving from a rebuilding roster into a legitimate contender in the Eastern Conference. After exceeding expectations with a 44-38 season and a first-round appearance against the New York Knicks in 2025, Detroit entered the 2026 season with continuity, internal development, and a clear upward trajectory.

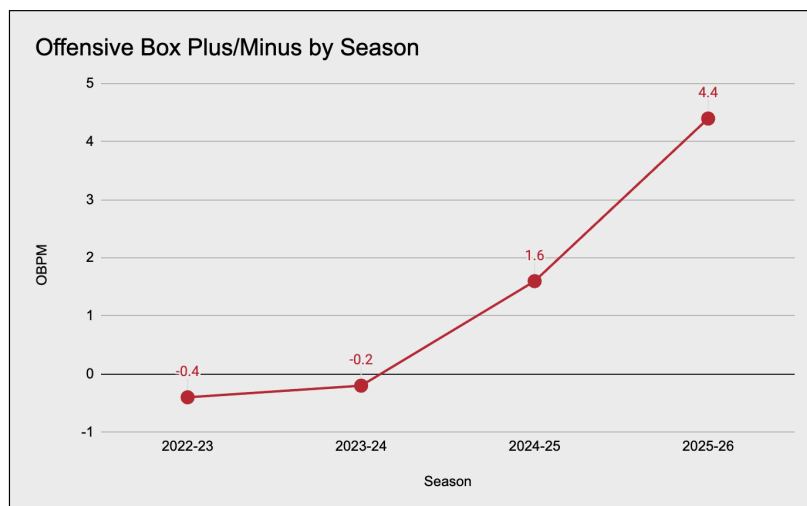
Detroit's turnaround didn't happen because of one player or one move. It came from several factors, including Cade Cunningham's continued development, another year of growth from the young core, and the culture established by J.B. Bickerstaff. Cunningham's availability has also played a role in shaping the team's offensive structure. After missing 18 games this season, his absences created extended opportunities for others to take on primary offensive responsibility. Within that broader context, the emergence of Jalen Duren has been a critical variable. His offensive leap has significantly raised the team's ceiling as a secondary offensive option and, if sustained, could further strengthen his case as a long-term piece within Detroit's core.

From a front office perspective, the decision not to extend Jalen Duren during the summer of 2025 appears to reflect organizational patience rather than hesitation. General manager Trajan Langdon has shown a tendency to avoid making premature long-term commitments. He likes to prioritize a larger sample size before solidifying key pieces of the roster. That approach is especially relevant in Duren's case, as he was not drafted by Langdon, making a more measured evaluation process both logical and necessary.

That evaluation window, however, proved to be brief. Early in the 2026 season, Duren's increased production made it clear he was becoming more than a supporting piece. His offensive growth gave Detroit another reliable scoring option alongside Cade Cunningham and strengthened the foundation of the team's young core.

The numbers back that up. Duren's Offensive Box Plus/Minus, a possession-based estimate of offensive impact, has trended upward each season, with a particularly sharp increase from 2025 to 2026 (see Figure 1).

Figure 1



In 2025, Jalen Duren averaged 11.8 points per game on an elite 69.2% shooting, attempting 7 field goals in 26.1 minutes per game. By 2026, that production jumped to 19.5 points per game on 65% shooting, with his volume rising to 11.5 attempts in 28.2 minutes. The combination of increased usage and sustained efficiency highlights a significant offensive leap, one that ranks 2nd among all qualified players in year-over-year scoring increase (behind only Nickeil Alexander-Walker). Duren isn’t just capitalizing on more opportunities, he’s operating in a more demanding role within the offense and handling greater volume while expanding the ways in which he generates scoring.

The scale of that leap firmly places him in the Most Improved Player conversation. But raw numbers alone don’t capture the full picture. The more important question, and the focus of this analysis, is not whether Duren has improved offensively, but what’s driving that leap and how it’s showing up on the floor.

Increased Offensive Role and Usage

One of the biggest reasons for Duren's offensive jump has been his expanded role in Detroit's offense. Usage rate data (Figures 2 and 3) illustrate a meaningful shift from a low-to-mid usage finisher in 2025 (ranked 20th among centers) to a secondary offensive hub in 2026 (6th among centers). Rather than operating primarily as a play finisher, Duren has been integrated more directly into the team’s offensive initiation and continuity actions, effectively functioning as a 1B option alongside Cade Cunningham.

This shift is most evident in his volume metrics. Duren is attempting 6.8 more field goals per 100 possessions compared to last season, a substantial increase that reflects both trust and expanded offensive responsibility. This is not empty volume, his increased involvement is paired with sustained efficiency, indicating that his role has scaled without compromising offensive effectiveness.

Figure 2

2025 Pistons USG% Leaders					
Player	Pos	G	MPG	USG%	
Cade Cunningham	PG	70	35.0	33.2	
Jaden Ivey	SG	30	29.9	26	
Malik Beasley	SG	82	27.8	22.5	
Dennis Schröder	PG	28	25.2	19.6	
Marcus Sasser	PG	57	14.2	19.4	
Ausar Thompson	SF	59	22.5	19.1	
Ron Holland	SF	81	15.6	18.1	
Tobias Harris	PF	73	31.6	17.6	
Jalen Duren	C	78	26.1	16.4	
Simone Fontecchio	SF	75	16.5	15.8	
Tim Hardaway Jr.	SG	77	28.0	15.5	
Isaiah Stewart	C	72	19.9	12.4	

Figure 3

2026 Pistons USG% Leaders					
Player	Pos	G	MPG	USG%	
Cade Cunningham	PG	64	33.9	30.5	
Jalen Duren	C	70	28.2	23.6	
Daniss Jenkins	PG	72	20.2	21.5	
Paul Reed	C	65	13.9	20.6	
Ron Holland	SF	78	19.9	18.9	
Tobias Harris	PF	63	27.7	18.8	
Caris LeVert	SG	60	19.2	18.4	
Kevin Huerter	SG	25	20.5	18	
Ausar Thompson	SF	73	26.0	16.9	
Isaiah Stewart	C	58	22.7	16.6	
Duncan Robinson	SF	77	27.4	15.8	
Javonte Green	SG	82	17.6	14.8	

Being 6'10" and 250 pounds, Duren's size has always been one of his biggest strengths, but the bigger change this season has been how often and where Detroit is getting him involved offensively. His overall touch volume has increased by approximately 5 touches per game compared to last season, with a

notable rise in frontcourt involvement (roughly +4 frontcourt touches per game). The Pistons are clearly making a greater effort to involve Duren as a regular option in their half-court offense.

Looking at where those touches occur helps explain how his role has changed. Post-up touches have tripled from 0.4 to 1.2 per game, signaling a greater emphasis on leveraging his size and strength as a scoring and decision-making advantage. Also, his paint touches have increased from 7.9 to 10.6 per game (1st among all qualified players), pointing to more frequent involvement in interior actions and sustained presence in high-value scoring areas. These increases point to not just more opportunity, but more intentional deployment within the offensive structure.

What's most impressive isn't that Duren is getting more opportunities, it's that his efficiency has remained strong despite the increase in workload. The numbers suggest this isn't just a case of receiving more touches within the same role. Instead, he's taking on a wider range of offensive responsibilities and finding new ways to generate scoring opportunities.

From Finisher to Creator

The next question is whether Duren is simply getting more opportunities or whether the nature of his offense has changed. The evidence points toward the latter. While his role has expanded, he's also creating offense in ways that weren't common earlier in his career, making him less dependent on teammates to generate scoring chances.

The play-type data in Figure 4 helps show how his offensive role has changed. In 2025, Duren's offensive profile was heavily concentrated in putback opportunities, which accounted for 23.8% of his possessions, a clear indicator of a reactive, play-finishing role. In 2026, that dependency has decreased as his offensive portfolio has diversified, with increases in isolation (+2.3%), post-up (+5.9%), spot-up (+2.6%), and cutting (+2.9%) possessions.

For this analysis, play types were grouped into four categories: "Create" (isolation, pick-and-roll ball handler, post-ups), "Finish" (putbacks, cuts, roll man, and other assisted actions), "Space" (spot-up, handoff, and off-screen actions), and "Transition." Using that breakdown (Figure 5), the change becomes clear: Duren's "Create" share has increased by approximately 8%, while his share of finishing actions has declined.

Figure 4

Play Type	Play Type Evolution 24/25 -> 25/26					
	Frequency (%)			Efficiency (PPP)		
	24/25	25/26	Diff	24/25	25/26	Diff
Isolation	6.2	8.5	2.3	1.02	1.05	0.03
Transition	16.1	13	-3.1	1.41	1.28	-0.13
Pick&Roll Ball Handler	2.5	2.8	0.3	1.35	1	-0.35
Pick&Roll Roll Man	16	15.3	-0.7	1.21	1.45	0.24
Post Up	3.8	9.7	5.9	1.23	1.22	-0.01
Spot Up	3.5	6.1	2.6	1.14	1.3	0.16
Cut	17.2	20.1	2.9	1.41	1.37	-0.04
Putbacks	23.8	16.4	-7.4	1.2	1.27	0.07
Misc	10.7	7.1	-3.6	0.2	0.42	0.22

Figure 5

Summarized Play Type Frequency			
PlayType	2025	2026	
Create	13%	21%	
Space	4%	6%	
Transition	16%	13%	
Finish	68%	59%	

That shift is also reflected in his driving volume. After averaging just 1.9 drives per game in 2025, Duren increased that number to 3.6 drives per game in 2026, a significant jump for a player previously utilized almost exclusively as a play finisher. The increase shows that Duren is more

comfortable handling the ball in space, and that Detroit's coaching staff trusts him more in those situations. Rather than relying solely on guards to create opportunities for him, Duren is now generating more offense on his own through drives and face-up situations.

Shot location data further reinforces this transformation. In 2025, an overwhelming 79.5% of Duren’s field goal attempts came from the restricted area, reflecting a highly condensed scoring profile. In 2026 (Figure 6), that distribution has expanded outward, with increased volume in both the non-restricted paint and mid-range zones. Duren is still primarily an interior scorer, but the increase in non-restricted paint and mid-range attempts shows a greater willingness to operate away from the rim. Even if those shots aren't yet a major part of his game, they add another layer to his offensive profile and give defenders more to think about than simply protecting the basket.

Figure 6

Shot Zone Evolution 24/25 -> 25/26						
Zone	Frequency (%)			Efficiency (FG%)		
	24/25	25/26	Diff	24/25	25/26	Diff
Restricted Area	79.5%	68.2%	-11.2%	72.8%	72.8%	0.0%
In The Paint (Non-RA)	20.0%	27.5%	7.6%	54.1%	50.2%	-3.9%
Mid-Range	0.5%	4.2%	3.7%	100.0%	35.3%	-64.7%

The shot charts in Figures 7 and 8 show this change visually, with more attempts occurring away from the restricted area than in previous seasons. Even without elite efficiency from these areas, the willingness to take these shots introduces new defensive considerations. Duren’s improved coordination and ball-handling allow him to attack closeouts, navigate into short pull-ups, and create scoring opportunities that were missing from his game a season ago.

Figure 7

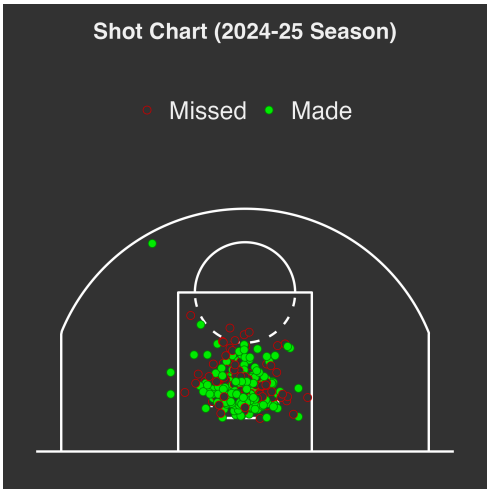
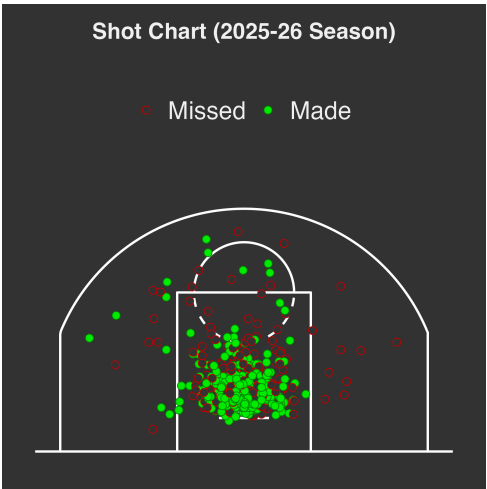


Figure 8



Shot-type analysis (Figure 9) gives perhaps the clearest evidence of this shift in offensive identity. Self-created opportunities have increased significantly, with driving layups accounting for a 10.5% higher share of his shot profile. On the other hand, assisted and opportunistic finishes, such as putback layups, tip-ins, and alley-oop dunks, have all declined in frequency. His overall dunk rate has dropped from 44%

to 25%, while layups have increased from 40.5% to 52%, indicating a move toward more controlled, skill-based finishes rather than purely vertical, play-dependent scoring.

Figure 9

Shot Type Evolution 24/25 -> 25/26				
Season		2024-25	2025-26	Diff
Shot Type 1	Shot Type 2			
Layup	Running	2.0%	3.0%	1.0%
	Regular	4.2%	9.0%	4.8%
	Putback/Tip	16.5%	11.2%	-5.3%
	Driving	9.5%	20.0%	10.5%
	Cutting	6.0%	6.2%	0.2%
	Alley Oop	2.2%	2.7%	0.5%
Layup Total		40.5%	52.2%	11.7%
Jump Shot	Turnaround	1.1%	2.9%	1.8%
	Regular	0.9%	2.5%	1.6%
	Pullup	0.5%	3.0%	2.4%
	Floater	3.8%	6.4%	2.5%
Jump Shot Total		6.4%	14.7%	8.3%
Hook Shot	Turnaround	4.2%	3.5%	-0.7%
	Regular	1.1%	2.4%	1.3%
	Driving	3.7%	2.2%	-1.4%
Hook Shot Total		9.0%	8.1%	-0.9%
Dunk	Running	4.4%	3.1%	-1.3%
	Regular	4.2%	3.6%	-0.6%
	Putback/Tip	10.6%	3.7%	-6.9%
	Driving	3.5%	1.9%	-1.6%
	Cutting	6.4%	3.7%	-2.7%
	Alley Oop	15.0%	9.0%	-6.1%
Dunk Total		44.1%	25.0%	-19.1%

These changes point to a player whose offensive game is becoming more complete. Duren is still at his best around the rim, but he's creating a larger share of his own offense than he was a year ago. The growth in his self-created offense gives Detroit more flexibility and raises his long-term offensive upside.

Free Throw Generation and Efficiency

One result of Duren's larger offensive role has been a significant increase in the pressure he puts on opposing defenses. As his role has shifted from a low-usage finisher to a more dynamic and assertive scoring option, defenders are being forced into more reactive positions, often resulting in trips to the free throw line.

The increase shows up clearly in his free throw rate, which has jumped from 0.385 across his first three seasons to 0.535 in 2026. That level of increase is not small, it represents a fundamental change in how frequently Jalen Duren is generating contact relative to his shot attempts. He averaged just 2.8 free throw attempts per game across his first three seasons, compared to 6.1 attempts per game in 2026, a substantial jump that reinforces both his increased offensive role and a more aggressive scoring approach.

The source of this jump is particularly telling. Post-up efficiency and frequency (discussed in prior sections) have translated directly into higher foul rates. In 2025, just 10% of his post-up possessions resulted in free throws. In 2026, that figure increased to 31.1%. The increase points to better positioning, stronger post play, and an improved ability to force defenders into fouls.

Getting to the line more often is only part of the story. Duren has also become more reliable once he gets there. Free throw shooting, often a limiting factor for interior bigs, has almost become a strength

instead of a liability. After converting at 69.1% through his first three seasons, he has improved to 74.7% in 2026. While not elite, this level of efficiency meaningfully alters the risk-reward calculation for opposing defenses.

The impact goes beyond the extra points he scores at the free throw line. Defenders now have to be more careful when contesting him around the basket because sending him to the line is no longer an easy tradeoff. As a result, Duren is putting more pressure on opposing defenses and creating situations where they have fewer good options. That's a meaningful change from earlier in his career, when fouling him carried much less risk.

Final Notes

For Pistons fans, Duren's breakout season probably isn't a surprise. Early indicators were evident as far back as his rookie season, including a standout performance against the San Antonio Spurs in which he posted 30 points, 17 rebounds, and 4 blocks in an overtime win, an outing that sparked early comparisons to Dwight Howard due to his physical tools and interior dominance at such a young age. What has changed since then is not just opportunity, but context: Duren is now operating within a more structured and functional offensive system, surrounded by complementary talent and guided by a coaching staff that is maximizing his skill set.

His development is also closely tied to the trajectory of Cade Cunningham, with the two forming a foundational pairing that defines Detroit's present and future. As the Pistons enter the first round of the 2026 playoffs, their ceiling will largely depend on how far Cunningham and Duren can continue to develop together. If Duren's offensive growth this season is indicative of his long-term trajectory, the range of outcomes expands significantly, not just for him individually, but for the organization as a whole.

From a front office perspective, the decision not to extend Jalen Duren during the 2025 offseason has become a point of debate. In hindsight, his current level of production indicates Detroit will likely face a significantly higher financial commitment this summer than it would have a year ago. At the same time, that outcome is largely a reflection of Duren's own development, as he has clearly played his way into a more lucrative deal and earned the contract that now awaits him.

Another factor worth mentioning is Duren's contract situation. While difficult to quantify, it's reasonable to view Duren's contract situation as a source of motivation throughout the season. Without the security of a long-term extension, he had added incentive to elevate his play and establish his value, a dynamic that may not have existed to the same degree had a deal already been in place.

Regardless of the reasons behind it, Duren's improvement this season has been significant. The numbers show a more productive player, but the film and play-type data suggest something more important: a broader offensive skill set. Whether this season proves to be a breakout year or the beginning of a larger trend will depend on how he continues to develop, but Detroit now has strong evidence that he can be a long-term cornerstone of its roster.

Data & Methodology

All statistical data used in this analysis was sourced from Basketball Reference and NBA.com/stats, with additional data access facilitated through the NBA Stats API (nba_api Python package). Traditional and advanced metrics were primarily sourced from Basketball Reference.

Player tracking data, including touches, play types, and shot zones, was sourced from NBA.com/stats, with play-type data further grouped into broader categories for analysis. Shot chart data was accessed via nba_api and used to evaluate changes in shot distribution.

Shot-type analysis was supplemented by manual review of Jalen Duren's field goal attempts across the 2024–25 and 2025–26 seasons, with each attempt categorized based on the shot type recorded by in-game statisticians and grouped into broader categories to analyze changes in scoring profile.